Transoxania (the lands just east of the Oxus river). There, *amirs* (local Mongol chiefs) wielded the real power. Without them, the Chagatai khans had no hope of retaining their thrones, and Amir Husayn was one of the most prominent kingmakers among all the amirs; he had personally engineered the coronation of the current Chagatai khan, Kabil Shah.[2]

Since at least the age of twenty-one, one of his biographers writes, Timur had been "very anxious to rebel against the Khan, and to assume [his] power." But Timur was not a descendant of the royal clan of Genghis Khan (despite the claims that later biographers made on his behalf), and he was not in pursuit of the khanate itself. He wanted power, not a title; dominance, not the mere appearance of it. He wanted the power of Amir Husayn, not the empty title of the puppet khan.[3]

Like the great Genghis Khan himself, he was a fierce and charismatic fighter. The fifteenth-century warrior-historian Mirza Muhammad Haidar quotes a verse made in Timur's honor, by those who had seen him in battle: when he seized his sword, he "made such sparks fly from it that / The sun in comparison seemed dark / He charged down like a roaring lion."[4]

His battle frenzies had won him a loyal following among Amir Husayn's soldiers, and their loyalty was only increased by his habit of giving away much of the battle spoil to his troops. He gave them clothing, jewels, horses, weapons, and belts, and (says a contemporary, the court historian Sharaf ad-din Ali Yazdi) thanked them for their bravery by sending them, "in cups of gold, the most delicious wines by the hands of the most beautiful women in the world." It was a generosity that Amir Husayn, stingy by nature, never displayed.[5]

"As the power of Amir Timur rose, so did the star of felicity of Amir Husain begin to decline," writes Haidar. When he felt himself strong enough, Timur turned on Amir Husayn. He laid siege to his former master, trapping him in his capital city of Balkh; on April 10, the defenses broke and Timur's army flooded in. Timur took his brother-in-law captive and allowed one of his officers, a man with a blood feud against Husayn, to murder him.[6]

From that time on, Timur ruled in Husayn's place as amir of Transoxania, with Samarkand as his capital. He ruled in the name of the Chagatai Khanate, but his conquests were all his own. Seventeen long years of campaigning moved his border steadily westward: Khwarezm, Isfahan, Tabriz, the lands south of the Caspian Sea.[7]

Timur was a throwback, an atavistic combination of Mongol nomad and Assyrian king. He had no interest in diplomacy, scolding his officers for displaying too much restraint: "He was dissatisfied with the gentle way in